

He is first documented in 1580, when he was in Paris, serving as a retainer in the household of the English ambassador, Sir Henry Cobham. John had probably already learned to play the lute in an aristocratic household of this kind. While in France, he took the fateful step of converting to Catholicism—a move that would have a profound effect on his future career.



PAGES FROM *THE FIRSTE BOOKE OF SONGES OR
AYRES*

The original, 1597 edition of John Dowland's highly successful *Firste Booke of Songes or Ayres* is shown here, with its innovative "table layout."

Home and abroad

Dowland returned to England in the mid-1580s and earned a music degree at Oxford University. He also married and had a son. In music circles, his reputation was growing. Some of his songs were performed at royal entertainments and, in 1594, he felt confident enough to apply for a vacant post as a court lutenist. He was rejected, however—apparently because of his